

SHAKY GROUND
CM Mohan Yadav at an ashram in Ujjain, May 15

HOW YADAV MEASURES UP

CM Mohan Yadav's governing style, power-building and navigation of political and administrative challenges

STRENGTHS

- **Decisive:** Clears proposals quickly once convinced, ensuring swift execution
- **Strategic restraint:** Avoids public confrontation and lets the party respond politically
- **Team-builder:** Has cultivated a trusted circle in the government as well as the party
- **Balances governance and ideology:** Pushes development while accommodating key Sangh priorities

CHALLENGES

- **Centralises authority:** Holding 11 portfolios risks slowing decision-making
- **Bureaucratic friction:** Differences with top officials, and frequent changes at secretariat have affected continuity
- **Assertive bureaucracy:** BJP legislators complain officials increasingly dominate governance
- **Managing veterans:** Equations with senior BJP leaders continue to require careful handling

ONE OF YADAV'S MOST STRIKING DECISIONS HAS BEEN TO RETAIN AS MANY AS 11 PORTFOLIOS, WHILE MOST SENIOR MINISTERS IN HIS 30-MEMBER CABINET OVERSEE JUST ONE MAJOR DEPARTMENT

that land holdings belonging to Yadav, and his immediate and extended family members, had grown multifold during the years he rose from minister to chief minister. It further claimed that several parcels acquired by family members were located in areas that later stood to benefit from government development projects announced during his tenure.

The Congress seized on the report, seeking Yadav's resignation and alleging that his family had made windfall gains while he held high office. State party president Jitendra Patwari demanded that Yadav explain the allegations in the media. At a press conference in Delhi, he also asked for a probe headed by a serving Supreme Court judge.

Yadav, however, chose to remain silent, while the BJP quickly closed ranks behind him. Around half a dozen party leaders came out in his defence, with party IT cell chief Amit Malviya issuing a statement backing the CM. State BJP president Hemant Khandelwal rejected the allegations, arguing that the combined land holdings of Yadav and his wife, Seema, in Ujjain had remained unchanged since before he became CM. He said members of Yadav's extended family had been in the real estate business for years. He also pointed out that Ujjain's Development Plan had been announced in May 2023, before Yadav became CM.

Khandelwal, however, did not address allegations that Siddhivinayak Devcon—a company in which Yadav and his wife together hold a 73 per cent stake—had purchased 2.6 acres after he became CM, sold 12 acres to a firm owned by Yadav's cousin, Neelesh, during his tenure, or that the CM's daughter-in-law acquired another 10 acres in mid-2025.

The issue is likely to come up during the monsoon sessions of both Parliament and the state assembly this month.

THE YADAV ASCENDANCY

When the BJP picked Yadav as CM after its sweeping victory in the 2023 assembly election, it surprised even seasoned party observers. First elected from Ujjain South in 2013, Yadav had won three consecutive terms and served as higher education minister in the Shivraj Singh Chouhan government between 2020 and 2023, yet he was hardly among the frontrunners for the top job. A farmer by background, Yadav also worked in the family's restaurant business before